First Read

Tencent Holdings

3Q26 preview; AI investment likely weighs on near-term margins

Equities

China
Internet Services

12-month rating **Buy**

12m price target	**HK$740.00**
	Prior : HK$770.00
Price (14 Oct 2026)	**HK$423.40**

RIC: 0700.HK **BBG:** 700 HK

Trading data and key metrics

52-wk range	HK$657.00-411.40
Market cap.	HK$3,847b/US$490b
Shares o/s	9,085m (ORD)
Free float	66%
Avg. daily volume ('000)	23,270
Avg. daily value (m)	HK$10,471.1
Common s/h equity (12/26E)	Rmb1323b
P/BV (12/26E)	2.4x
Net debt to EBITDA (12/26E)	NM

EPS (UBS, diluted) (CNY)

	From	To	% ch	Cons.
12/26E	29.10	28.57	-2	29.33
12/27E	29.52	28.02	-5	31.16
12/28E	32.74	31.05	-5	33.77

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3Q26 preview

We expect 3Q **revenue** to moderate +7% YoY (2Q's +11%), with **adj. NP** -7% to Rmb65bn (2Q's +9%) on AI investment drag and likely lower share of profits from asso (lower stake and earnings from Kuaishou). By segment: **1) Games**: i) Domestic: We expect growth to moderate to +12% for 3Q amid higher base (2Q's +17%). Based on our checks, grossing of evergreen titles (i.e. *Honor of Kings*, *PeaceKeeper Elite* and *Delta Force*) remained resilient, where *HoK: King of Chess* (launched on 10 Sep) and emerging titles (i.e. *Golden Spatula* and *Valorant*) also contributed to growth. ii) International: We forecast growth to decelerate to -3% (2Q's -1%) on weak Supercell performance and limited new launches in 3Q. **2) Ad**: anticipated at +18% YoY (2Q's +22%), moderating on continued macro headwinds, which capped the benefits from ad tech upgrades, Video Accounts' increasing ad load, and higher eCPM ad formats (e.g rewarded ads, and closed-loop ads). **3) FinTech (FBS)**: estimated largely steady at +8% (2Q's +9%), amid soft payment growth but slightly accelerating cloud growth on improving chip availability and incremental Workbuddy subscription income. **4) Margin**: We model GP +9% YoY (GPM 57.2%, +0.8pp YoY) on favourable mix towards high margin businesses. On higher depreciation and AI opex (UBSe Rmb16bn), we forecast **adj. OP** to turn -ve at -2% YoY to Rmb71bn. Excluding AI investment, Tencent should continue to register operating leverage with +13% adj. OP growth (2Q's +19%).

Key focuses into result

1) AI strategy and capex: The market will likely focus on Tencent's model and AI product rollout, for which we have observed +ve progress. These include HY4.0 model (launched in Aug), WorkBuddy (mgmt highlighted strong inference demand, with daily token usage surging 5x from 5tn to 25tn from Jun to Aug, and the increasing revenue recognition from subscription in 3Q), and Xiaowei (Weixin agent) trial since early June. In addition, WorkBuddy's integration with office applications across Tencent's ecosystem, such as WeCom, should help broaden enterprise adoption and support further cloud revenue growth. Accordingly, we forecast Tencent's 2026E/27E capex at Rmb250bn/230bn, which could weigh on near-term margins.

2) Core business especially for online games: i) Domestic: While grossing should have remained resilient at HSD% YoY in 3Q based on our checks, 4Q growth could continue to face pressure (cons +11%) with no major title launch amid tougher growth comp. *CrossFire: Rainbow* is the most promising title in the pipeline, and is expected to launch in 2027. Despite moderating topline growth, AI-enabled and more frequent content creation and update, and lower iOS commission (effective since Mar) could provide potential margin upside. ii) International: Amid moderating performance in Supercell and increasing revenue recognition from IAA in Miniclip's casual games (rather

Highlights (Rmbm)	12/23	12/24	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E	12/29E	12/30E
Revenues	609,015	660,257	751,766	816,106	895,086	969,776	1,049,764	1,137,452
EBIT (UBS)	205,694	253,815	297,565	305,288	293,526	321,231	351,879	385,903
Net earnings (UBS)	157,688	222,703	259,626	261,417	253,880	278,465	305,605	335,682
EPS (UBS, diluted) (Rmb)	16.41	23.67	28.09	28.57	28.02	31.05	34.42	38.18
DPS (net) (Rmb)	3.46	4.57	5.39	5.51	5.44	6.05	6.74	7.52
Net (debt) / cash	13,503	(9,785)	(2,914)	25,660	68,870	229,350	420,175	647,068
Profitability/valuation	**12/23**	**12/24**	**12/25**	**12/26E**	**12/27E**	**12/28E**	**12/29E**	**12/30E**
EBIT (UBS) margin %	33.8	38.4	39.6	37.4	32.8	33.1	33.5	33.9
ROIC (EBIT) %	34.3	37.2	35.8	31.6	26.9	27.9	30.4	33.4
EV/EBITDA (UBS core) x	10.1	9.3	12.0	7.7	7.6	7.0	6.5	6.0
P/E (UBS, diluted) x	18.5	14.0	17.7	12.8	12.9	11.6	10.5	9.5
Equity FCF (UBS) yield %	6.2	5.5	4.1	3.7	4.1	7.7	8.7	10.0
Dividend yield (net) %	1.1	1.4	1.1	1.5	1.5	1.7	1.9	2.1

Source: Company accounts, LSEG Eikon, UBS estimates. Metrics marked as (UBS) have had analyst adjustments applied. Valuations: based on an average share price that year, (E): based on a share price of HK$ 423.40 on 14-Oct-2026

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than IAP booked under games), we remain cautious on its growth outlook. We believe Tencent's optimization efforts could take time to materialize (e.g. the recent leadership change for *Clash of Clans*).

Valuation and what to do with the stock

From a fundamental standpoint, investors generally favor Tencent mgmt's strong execution history, robust FCF across its core businesses, substantial agentic AI potential within the Weixin ecosystem, and its cRmb900bn investment portfolio, which could be unlocked. That said, investors' primary concerns appear to be: 1) the magnitude of EPS decline next year amid incremental AI investment, and 2) the timing when EPS downgrade cycle will conclude.

In terms of magnitude, we believe the net impact of AI investment should remain manageable at a single-digit percentage of Tencent's earnings. Tencent's 2026E core OP, excluding AI investment, is cRmb345bn, +15% YoY. **On growth**: Assuming 10% growth in 2027E, this would generate Rmb35bn of incremental OP. **On cost**: We conservatively estimate investment in new AI products at Rmb55bn in 2026E (2025: Rmb18bn) and doubles to Rmb110bn in 2027E (vs BABA's FY27E Rmb45bn loss in AI labs and applications). **Net net**, Tencent's Rmb55bn of incremental AI investment should be largely offset by cRmb35bn of core OP growth, leaving a net drag of Rmb20bn, or c7% of adj. OP in a very conservative scenario. If monetization in AI products is earlier than expected, it would provide upside potential. **Accordingly, we believe the net impact could be smaller than investors' current expectation.**

From a timing standpoint, while buyside expectations have already declined, sellside currently forecasts 4Q26E/2027E adj. NP growth of 0%/+4% YoY, compared with UBSe of -8%/-3%. We expect the street to gradually and fully incorporate the AI-related drag over the next 1-2 quarters. Once the EPS downgrade cycle concludes, the stock could begin to re-rate, in our view.

Overall, we reiterate our Buy rating on Tencent. Trading at a relatively undemanding 13x 2027E P/E, the current valuation should provide an attractive entry point for long-term investors, even if additional EPS reductions occur relative to our already conservative base case. We cut 2026E-28E adj. EPS by 2-5% and our SOPT-based PT to HK$740 (from HK$780).

Figure 1: 3Q26 preview summary

(Rmb m)	3Q25	2Q26	3Q26E	QoQ	YoY	Cons	+/-
a. VAS	**95,860**	**98,414**	**98,214**	**-0.2%**	**2.5%**	**101,623**	**-3.4%**
Domestic games	42,760	47,314	47,677	0.8%	11.5%	47,902	-0.5%
International games	20,800	18,600	20,176	8.5%	-3.0%	20,802	-3.0%
Core social network	32,300	32,500	30,362	-6.6%	-6.0%	32,854	-7.6%
b. Marketing services	**36,242**	**43,565**	**42,664**	**-2.1%**	**17.7%**	**43,133**	**-1.1%**
c. Fintech & business services	**58,174**	**60,286**	**62,897**	**4.3%**	**8.1%**	**63,459**	**-0.9%**
d. Others	**2,593**	**2,520**	**2,852**	**13.2%**	**10.0%**	**2,714**	**5.1%**
Total revenue	**192,869**	**204,785**	**206,627**	**0.9%**	**7.1%**	**211,133**	**-2.1%**
YoY % chg	***15.4%***	***11.0%***	***7.1%***			***9.5%***	***-2.3%***
Gross profit	**108,798**	**118,433**	**118,196**	**-0.2%**	**8.6%**	**119,929**	**-1.4%**
YoY % chg	*22.5%*	*12.8%*	*8.6%*			*10.3%*	*-1.6%*
GPM %	***56.4%***	***57.8%***	***57.2%***	***-0.6pcts***	***0.8pcts***	***56.8%***	***0.4pcts***
Value added services	61.2%	63.9%	64.7%	*0.7pcts*	*3.5pcts*	62.9%	*1.8pcts*
Marketing services	56.7%	57.3%	56.5%	*-0.8pcts*	*-0.2pcts*	57.0%	*-0.5pcts*
Fintech and business services	50.2%	52.1%	50.0%	*-2.1pcts*	*-0.2pcts*	50.3%	*-0.3pcts*
Others	16.0%	-35.1%	-30.1%	*5.0pcts*	*-46.0pcts*	-15.9%	*-14.2pcts*
Selling and marketing	(11,468)	(11,869)	(14,877)	25.3%	29.7%	(13,061)	13.9%
General and administrative	(34,259)	(38,808)	(40,912)	5.4%	19.4%	(41,564)	-1.6%
Non-GAAP operating profit	**72,570**	**75,636**	**71,348**	**-5.7%**	**-1.7%**	**73,475**	**-2.9%**
Adj. OPM %	*37.6%*	*36.9%*	*34.5%*	*-2.4pcts*	*-3.1pcts*	*34.8%*	*-0.3pcts*
YoY % chg	*18.4%*	*9.2%*	*-1.7%*			*1.2%*	*-235.1%*
Share of gains from associates and JVs	7,854	(9,993)	5,381	-153.8%	-31.5%	3,273	64.4%
Income tax expense	(9,785)	(11,713)	(12,747)	8.8%	30.3%	(12,669)	0.6%
Non-GAAP net profit	**70,551**	**68,415**	**65,384**	**-4.4%**	**-7.3%**	**68,302**	**-4.3%**
YoY % chg	*18.0%*	*8.5%*	*-7.3%*			*-3.2%*	*-4.1%*
Adj. NPM %	*36.6%*	*33.4%*	*31.6%*	*-1.8pcts*	*-4.9pcts*	*32.4%*	*-0.7pcts*

Source: Visible Alpha, Company data, UBS estimates

Figure 2: UBSe 2026E-28E estimate changes

	New estimates			Prior estimates			% chg		
(Rmb m)	2026E	2027E	2028E	2026E	2027E	2028E	2026E	2027E	2028E
a. VAS	**383,589**	**413,101**	**437,543**	**385,853**	**416,496**	**442,077**	**-1%**	**-1%**	**-1%**
Domestic games	181,631	197,612	209,949	182,782	195,727	206,127	-1%	1%	2%
International games	78,073	84,319	91,064	78,846	88,308	97,138	-1%	-5%	-6%
Core social network	123,885	131,170	136,529	124,225	132,461	138,812	0%	-1%	-2%
b. Marketing services	**172,628**	**197,042**	**221,381**	**172,628**	**197,042**	**221,381**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
c. Fintech & business services	**249,389**	**273,392**	**298,148**	**249,389**	**273,392**	**298,148**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
d. Others	**10,500**	**11,550**	**12,705**	**10,500**	**11,550**	**12,705**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
Total revenue	**816,106**	**895,086**	**969,776**	**818,370**	**898,481**	**974,311**	**0%**	**0%**	**0%**
YoY % chg	***8.6%***	***9.7%***	***8.3%***	***8.9%***	***9.8%***	***8.4%***			
Gross profit	**466,805**	**513,921**	**559,890**	**468,244**	**518,388**	**565,533**	**0%**	**-1%**	**-1%**
YoY % chg	*10.5%*	*10.1%*	*8.9%*	*10.8%*	*10.7%*	*9.1%*			
GPM %	***57.2%***	***57.4%***	***57.7%***	***57.2%***	***57.7%***	***58.0%***	***0.0pcts***	***-0.3pcts***	***-0.3pcts***
Value added services	63.6%	64.1%	64.4%	63.6%	64.1%	64.4%	*0.0pcts*	*0.0pcts*	*0.0pcts*
Marketing services	57.3%	57.5%	57.7%	57.3%	57.5%	57.7%	*0.0pcts*	*0.0pcts*	*0.0pcts*
Fintech and business services	51.2%	50.9%	50.9%	51.2%	51.4%	51.6%	*0.0pcts*	*-0.5pcts*	*-0.7pcts*
Others	-35.0%	-28.0%	-10.0%	-35.0%	-20.0%	-5.0%	*0.0pcts*	*-8.0pcts*	*-5.0pcts*
Selling and marketing	(56,724)	(73,849)	(79,042)	(55,244)	(65,145)	(69,668)	3%	13%	13%
General and administrative	(157,979)	(201,910)	(217,789)	(156,780)	(199,082)	(214,910)	1%	1%	1%
Non-GAAP operating profit	**288,764**	**277,002**	**304,706**	**292,001**	**293,120**	**322,760**	**-1%**	**-5%**	**-6%**
Adj. OPM %	*35.4%*	*30.9%*	*31.4%*	*35.7%*	*32.6%*	*33.1%*	*-0.3pcts*	*-1.7pcts*	*-1.7pcts*
YoY % chg	*2.9%*	*-4.1%*	*10.0%*	*4.0%*	*0.4%*	*10.1%*			
Share of gains from associates and JVs	3,506	19,666	21,633	5,943	20,139	22,152	-41%	-2%	-2%
Income tax expense	(50,382)	(48,237)	(53,177)	(51,013)	(50,870)	(56,126)	-1%	-5%	-5%
Non-GAAP net profit	**261,417**	**253,880**	**278,465**	**266,299**	**267,410**	**293,613**	**-1.8%**	**-5.1%**	**-5.2%**
YoY % chg	*0.7%*	*-2.9%*	*9.7%*	*2.6%*	*0.4%*	*9.8%*			
Adj. NPM %	*32.0%*	*28.4%*	*28.7%*	*32.5%*	*29.8%*	*30.1%*	*-0.5pcts*	*-1.4pcts*	*-1.4pcts*

Source: Company data, UBS estimates

Figure 3: Valuation

	Business segment	Valuation (HK$mn)	Per share (HK$)	Mix (%)	Valuation methodology
	Core business				
1)	PC games	553,714	60.5	9%	12x 2026E EBIT multiple
2)	Mobile games	1,452,291	158.7	24%	12x 2026E EBIT multiple
3)	Social and advertising (ex. video)	2,020,062	220.7	33%	14x 2026E EBIT multiple
4)	Video	9,763	1.1	0%	Market valuation
5)	Music	54,376	5.9	1%	Market valuation
6)	Fintech	690,458	75.4	11%	3x 2026E P/S
7)	Cloud	205,951	22.5	3%	3x 2026E P/S
	Core business valuation	**4,986,616**	**544.9**	**83%**	
	Investment				
	Listed associates	269,735	29.5	4%	Fair value as of 2Q26
	Unlisted associates	162,551	17.8	3%	1x reported book value as of 2Q26
	Financial assets - FVPL	253,652	27.7	4%	Fair value as of 2Q26
	Financial assets - FVOCI	364,049	39.8	6%	Fair value as of 2Q26
8)	**Total investment portfolio**	**1,049,988**	**114.7**	**17%**	
	Target valuation	**6,036,604**	**660**		
	Valuation (HK$)	660	end-2025E		
	Price target (HK$)	**740**	end-Oct 27E		

Source: Company data, UBS estimates

Forecast returns

Forecast price appreciation	74.8%
Forecast dividend yield	1.5%
Forecast stock return	76.3%
Market return assumption	10.5%
Forecast excess return	65.8%

Company Description

Tencent has the largest online community in China. It was founded with the launch of instant messaging platform QQ but has since grown into a diversified internet company with core focuses on gaming, social media and networking (Weixin/WeChat), fintech (WeChat Pay), cloud computing and digital content. The company also holds a substantial investment portfolio of public and private companies.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Our price target is based on sum of the parts.
We believe the key risks for Tencent include: 1) an evolving and intensifying competitive landscape; 2) new business execution; 3) integration of invested companies and businesses; 4) rising costs of traffic acquisition, content and brand promotions; 5) IT system upkeep; 6) expansion into international markets; 7) infringement of intellectual property rights; 8) departures of key management; and 9) regulatory risks.

Quantitative Research Review

UBS Global Research publishes a quantitative assessment of its analysts' responses to certain questions about the likelihood of an occurrence of a number of short term factors in a product known as the 'Quantitative Research Review'. The views for this month can be found below. Views contained in this assessment on a particular stock reflect only the views on those short term factors which are a different timeframe to the 12-month timeframe reflected in any equity rating set out in this note. For previous responses please make reference to (i) previous UBS Global Research reports; and (ii) where no applicable research report was published that month, the Quantitative Research Review which can be found at https://neo.ubs.com/quantitative, or contact your UBS sales representative for access to the report or the Quantitative Research Team on ubs-quant-answers@ubs.com. A consolidated report which contains all responses is also available and again you should contact your UBS sales representative for details and pricing or the Quantitative Research Team on the email above.

Tencent Holdings

Question	Response
1. Is the industry structure facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting worse, 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	3
2. Is the regulatory/government environment facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting tougher 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	3
3. Over the last 3-6 months in broad terms have things been improving/no change/getting worse for this stock? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting a lot worse, 3 = not much change, 5 = getting a lot better, N/A = no view)	4
4. Relative to the current CONSENSUS EPS forecast, is the next company EPS update likely to lead to: (1 = negative surprise vs consensus, 3 = in-line with consensus, 5 = positive surprise vs consensus expectations, N/A = no view)	3
5. What's driving the difference?	
6. Relative to YOUR current earnings forecast, is there relatively greater risk at the next earnings result of:(1 = downside skew risk to earnings, 3 = equal upside or downside risk to earnings, 5 = upside skew risk to earnings, N/A = no view)	3
7. What's driving the difference?	
8. Is there an upcoming catalyst for the company over the next three months?	
9. Is there an actual or approximate date for the catalyst?	
10. Is the catalyst date an actual or approximate date?	
11. What is the catalyst?	

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UBS Global Research: Global Equity Rating Definitions

12-Month Rating	Definition	Coverage[1]	IB Services[2]
Buy	FSR is > 6% above the MRA.	55%	24%
Neutral	FSR is between -6% and 6% of the MRA.	39%	20%
Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	6%	21%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 30 September 2026.
1:Percentage of companies under coverage globally within the 12-month rating category.
2:Percentage of companies within the 12-month rating category for which investment banking (IB) services were provided within the past 12 months.

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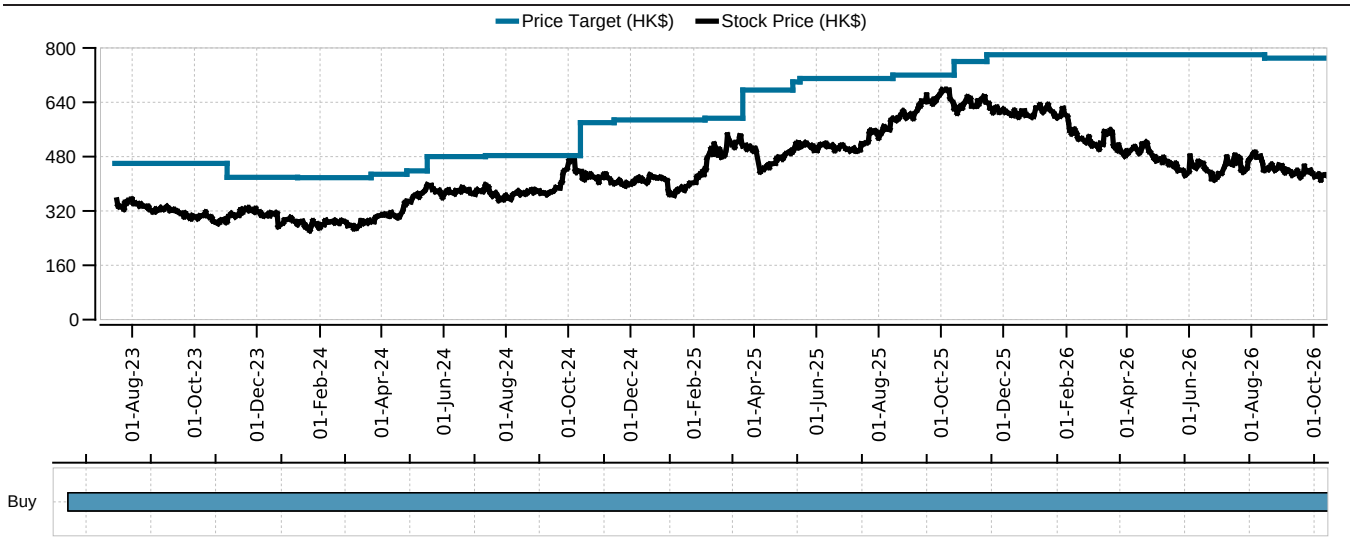
Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
Tencent Holdings[4,5,16,6,28]	0700.HK	Buy	HK$423.40	14 Oct 2026

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon. All prices as of local market close. Ratings in this table are the most current published ratings prior to this report. They may be more recent than the stock pricing date.

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Tencent Holdings (HK$)



Date	Stock Price (HK$)	Price Target (HK$)	Rating
2023-07-14	352.60	460.00	Buy
2023-11-01	287.00	419.00	Buy
2024-01-09	283.60	418.00	Buy
2024-03-21	291.20	428.00	Buy
2024-04-25	339.40	438.00	Buy
2024-05-15	381.80	480.00	Buy
2024-07-11	384.80	483.00	Buy
2024-10-12	438.80	580.00	Buy
2024-11-14	403.40	588.00	Buy
2025-02-11	427.40	593.00	Buy
2025-03-20	519.50	676.00	Buy
2025-05-08	498.00	700.00	Buy
2025-05-15	520.00	710.00	Buy
2025-08-14	590.00	720.00	Buy
2025-10-13	639.00	760.00	Buy

Date	Stock Price (HK$)	Price Target (HK$)	Rating
2025-11-14	641.00	780.00	Buy
2026-08-13	441.00	770.00	Buy

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 14-Oct-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

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